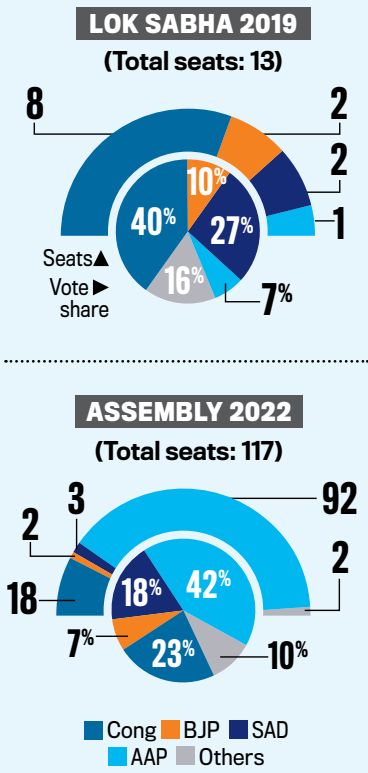


HELPING HAND Punjab CM Bhagwant Mann on a road show in support of AAP's Amritsar candidate Kuldeep Singh Dhaliwal, Apr. 25

SHIFTING FORTUNES

Within three years, the AAP's vote share spiralled from 7% in the 2019 Lok Sabha polls to 42% in the 2022 assembly election



Note: SAD & BJP were allies in LS 2019

Vote share figures have been rounded off



ANI

also vying for political space in select seats. Stirring this cauldron further, the 31-year-old radical Sikh preacher Amritpal Singh, lodged in an Assam jail after his arrest under the National Security Act charges last April, has announced his plans to enter the fray as an Independent from Khadoor Sahib. So, who has the upper hand?

Congress: A Tall Order

The Grand Old Party nurses hope to win the maximum of the state's 13 seats, capitalising on anti-incumbency sentiments against the Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann-led AAP government. In 2019, then chief minister Capt. Amarinder Singh had stitched together a formidable caste coalition, attracting even the traditionally Congress-averse Panthic (related to Sikh faith) voters and enabling the party to win eight seats—a remarkable feat amidst the Modi wave. However, his ouster and switch to the BJP, the Congress's dismal performance in the 2022 assembly polls (reduced to just 18 MLAs from 77 in the 117-member assembly), and the ascendancy of the AAP (it cornered 92 seats with a vote share of 42 per cent) have reshaped the dynamics. Not only does the Congress have to demonstrate that its new leadership wields a firm grasp over the cadre and projects a commanding presence to take on the AAP, but can also contain the BJP's rise and prevent the revival of the SAD's Panthic politics.

However, even before establish-